



ROUTEUP CAREER GUIDANCE SERIES — VOLUME 4

Choosing the Right Course and University

Rankings Myths, Employable Degrees, and the Shortlist Method

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The Course Decides More Than the Country

Two students land in the same city, same week. Three years later one has a career and PR prospects; the other is driving deliveries with a master's degree. The difference was usually decided before departure — in the course choice.

Myth: “A higher-ranked university guarantees a better outcome.”

Reality: Global rankings mostly measure research output, not graduate employment. Employers in your field often rate a specialised, industry-connected program above a famous name. Check the course's employment statistics, not the university's ranking.

Myth: “Popular course = safe course.”

Reality: By the time a course is 'what everyone is doing', its graduate market is crowded. Thousands of identical CVs from identical programs compete for the same entry roles. Demand at ENROLMENT time and demand at GRADUATION time are two different markets, two-plus years apart.

Myth: “I can switch to something better after I arrive.”

Reality: Course-switching mid-journey is a red flag at immigration stage — officers ask why, and 'the other course looked easier' has no good answer. In several countries it can also reset your post-study work eligibility. Choose as if you cannot switch.

The Alignment Rule

Your strongest application — to universities, to visa officers, and later to employers — is a straight line: past academics → chosen course → target occupation. Every bend in that line needs an explanation, and explanations are where applications die. Build on what you have; deepen rather than restart.

Questions that expose a weak course

- What percentage of last year's graduates found full-time work in the field within 6 months? (If the university can't tell you, that's the answer.)
- Is the course on the destination country's skills-shortage or PR-relevant occupation lists?
- Does it include internship/placement/co-op terms? Courses with built-in industry time consistently out-place classroom-only equivalents.
- Who accredits it professionally? An unaccredited engineering or health course can lock you out of the profession no matter your grades.

What consultancies won't tell you: agents earn commission per enrolment, and some private colleges pay far higher commission than good public universities. That is how students end up in expensive, low-outcome colleges 'recommended' with great confidence. Always ask any counsellor directly: does this institution pay you? An honest one will answer.

Worksheet — Your Shortlist Test

- ☐ My target occupation in 10 years: _____
- ☐ Course + university option 1: _____
- ☐ Course + university option 2: _____
- ☐ Course + university option 3: _____
- ☐ Each option builds directly on my previous academics (straight line, no bends)
- ☐ I have seen graduate employment data for each course, from a source other than the agent
- ☐ Each course appears on (or leads to) the country's in-demand occupation list

- ☐ At least one option includes a placement/internship term
 - ☐ I asked whether my counsellor receives commission from these institutions
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When to Get Help

Everything in this volume you can act on yourself — that is deliberate. But the worksheet you just filled has answers only YOU could write, and validating those answers against real requirements, real budgets, and real immigration rules is where mistakes hide.

Bring your completed course shortlist to session with RouteUp. We will go through it line by line and tell you honestly — including if your plan is fine and you don't need us further.

Book your free session: www.routeup.co.in · hello@routeup.co.in ·

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